

Moved River, Leased Hill: Kobe's Settlement and Meriken Park

Kobe was a village of sand and fields, picked for the foreign settlement because there was little there to disturb. A British engineer's leased grid rose by the shore in 1868; residents climbed the hillside above it, a flooding river was diverted to make room, and the harbor grew into today's Meriken Park. This dossier reads all three through what still stands.



メリケンパーク・北野（神戸市中央区）

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (7 chapters, about 1900 words)
2. Timeline
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A fan of gravel between the mountain and the sea

The study area is a narrow shelf where the streams running off Mount Rokko spread into a fan of gravel and sand, flatten into a river floodplain, and then meet a shoreline that has been almost entirely built out into the bay. Two rivers bounded the village the foreigners would inherit: the Koi-gawa (鯉川) to the west and the Ikuta-gawa (生田川) to the east, both fed by short, steep catchments that ran dry in summer and flooded without warning after rain. Kobe City's own 1925 history describes the ground between them as mostly dry field and paddy, with beach sand along the shore, a scatter of burial mounds, and the boat landing of Kobe village inside what would become the settlement.¹

The Ikuta River had a long literary life before it had a commercial one. An 1897 Kobe guidebook strings together a chain of classical poems on the river and on 生田磯, the strand in front of Ikuta Shrine, which it says older books place on the very coast later built up as the settlement. It also recalls the medieval tale, taken from the Yamato Monogatari, of the maiden of Unai and the two suitors who fought for her over this river until she drowned herself between them: a story much older than any consulate. To the west lay Hyogo, already a working port under the Taira and the Edo-period kitamae-bune trade; Kobe was chosen for the new foreign settlement precisely because it was the emptier, less-developed ground of the two, a point the settlement's own historical association still makes today.^{7 12}

A settlement built in less than a year

Kobe's port opened to foreign trade on 1 January 1868 (Keio 3, 12th month, 7th day), but the settlement that gave the port its foreign quarter was still a building site. The shogunate had only finished buying the land in the seventh month of 1867 by the old calendar, about four months before the port opened, and Kobe City's history, quoting a letter from the Hyogo magistrate Shibata Hyuga-no-kami, records that construction was about seventy percent complete by 16 December 1867; the Japan Chronicle's jubilee history, quoted in the same volume, says the settlement had still not reached the house-building stage by the end of May 1868. The shogunate's own accounts, reproduced in the same city history, put its total outlay above 220,000 ryo: land compensation, grading at one ryo a tsubo, a stone seawall costing 37,500 ryo, drains, and landfill costing more again.¹

The man who gave the settlement its famous grid was a British civil engineer, J. W. Hart, working to European planning practice: one hundred and twenty-six lots, straight streets, drains and street trees, sold to foreign leaseholders (never owners — Japan kept the freehold) in four auctions between September 1868 and February 1873. A contemporary English-language newspaper is said to have called it the best-planned foreign settlement in the East, and the grid it drew is still the street plan of the Kyu-Kyoryuchi business district today. The settlement stayed under foreign municipal self-government, paid for by its own residents' land tax, until Japan's revised treaties took effect and Japan resumed full administration of the area on 17 July 1899.¹²

Gunfire on the Kobe road

Five weeks after the port opened, the unfinished settlement produced Japan's first serious diplomatic crisis with the Western powers. On the eleventh day of the first month by the old calendar (4 February 1868), a column of troops from the Bizen (Okayama) domain, under the retainers Ikeda Ise and Heki Tatewaki, was marching through the Kobe road when foreign nationals crossed or interrupted its line of march; shots were fired. Kobe City's own documentary volume reproduces the exchange of notes that followed within a day: the resident foreign ministers warned Japan's new government on 5 February that unless the affair were settled to every power's satisfaction it could bring war on the whole country, not just Bizen, and foreign warships seized a Japanese steamer lying in Hyogo harbor as a guarantee. Bizen's own report of 7 February, also preserved in this volume, gives a different emphasis, blaming "unreasonable conduct by the foreigners" for the exchange of fire — a reminder that the Japanese and Western accounts of the Kobe Incident were not the same story even at the time.³⁶

The imperial court's representative, Higashikuze Michitomi, met the envoys of the six treaty powers in Hyogo on 8 February to settle how the settlement would be policed from then on. The affair itself was closed a few weeks later at the cost of one life: a library reference file assembled from more than a dozen histories and biographical dictionaries records that Taki Zenzaburo, the Bizen officer held responsible, committed seppuku at Eifuku-ji temple in Hyogo on 2 March 1868, watched by representatives of the foreign powers and by Japanese officials that included the young Ito Hirobumi. It did what the diplomats needed: no warship fired on Kobe.²⁶¹³

Moving a river, naming a street

The Ikuta River was the settlement's other problem. Kobe City recalls that the old river normally carried no more than a trickle but turned into a torrent after any prolonged rain, repeatedly damaging the low ground on its western bank where the foreign lots lay; the foreign residents pressed hard enough that the new Meiji government agreed to move it. A 1942 city guidebook, drawing on the engineering record, dates the decision to the second month of 1871 by the old calendar, construction from the third month, and completion in the sixth — a new channel about 1.8 km long and some 18 m wide dug well to the east of the old one. The old riverbed and its banks, more than 41,700 tsubo of land, were then auctioned in 1873; the city guide names the winning bidders as Arimoto Akira of Wakayama and Kano Soshichi of Kobe, though it is Kano's name the neighborhood still carries.⁶⁸

Kano laid an eighteen-meter road down the middle of the old riverbed at a time when an ordinary Kobe street was 3.6 m wide, and built house lots on either side; the district took his name, Kano-cho, and his road is Kobe's Flower Road today. A 1922 planning survey lists the river-moving as one of a run of large works — the settlement's own land readjustment in 1873, new roads the same year, the Osaka-Kobe railway in 1874, and the Hyogo Shinkawa canal, dug through the old port at Hyogo, in 1875 — and opens its own chapter by noting that Kobe had grown in fifty-odd years into Japan's third-largest city. The rebuilt Ikuta channel was itself culverted in 1931 for road space, then reopened as open water after the 1938 flood proved the culvert a liability.⁵⁶⁸

Up the hill, along the water

By the 1880s the settlement's original lots were full of offices and warehouses, and foreign residents who worked there began building houses on the gentler, better-aired slope above it, in what is now Kitano-cho and Yamamoto-dori. Kobe City dates the move to around 1887 and says more than two hundred Western- and Japanese-style houses eventually stood on the hillside; war and later redevelopment cut that to about eighty Western-style buildings by the time of the 1995 earthquake. The Agency for Cultural Affairs designated 9.3 hectares of the hillside an Important Preservation District for Groups of Traditional Buildings on 10 April 1980. The Weathercock House, the former Thomas residence and a national Important Cultural Property, stands inside it; the Hunter House, among the largest of Kobe's surviving foreign residences, was built on the slope but moved to Oji Zoo in 1963.^{10 1117}

Down on the water, the harbor grew wharf by wharf out from the settlement's shore. The pier that gave today's park its name was built in 1868 as a landing wharf for foreign cargo, near where the American consulate stood; Japanese ears heard "America" as "meriken," and Meriken Hatoba — the American Wharf — stuck as its name. The Naka pier immediately to its east, built out further into the bay, was completed in 1938. Trade statistics that Kobe City itself published year after year through the Meiji and Taisho eras — foreign and coastal cargo tonnage, ship arrivals, bonded-warehouse space — chart a port that grew, within the same fifty years as Kano's road and the settlement's own land sales, into one of the busiest in Asia.⁹¹⁶

Flood, fire and a broken quay

On 5 July 1938 the Ikuta and the other short rivers off Rokko produced the worst disaster in Kobe's modern history. Kobe City's own 1939 flood record describes rain building from the evening of 3 July — 165 mm fell in the twenty hours to 4 pm the next day — with landslides already breaking out across the hillside wards; a second, far heavier burst began before dawn on the 5th and peaked between 10 and 11 a.m., when 47.6 mm fell in a single hour and 134.4 mm in three. The Toga River's

embankment in Nada had already given way the previous afternoon. Debris flows the city called "mountain tsunami" swept down every steep valley behind the built-up area at once, and the first report of catastrophic damage reached city hall at about 10 a.m. on the 5th from Minato ward, where two rivers had burst their banks together.⁴

The same 1939 volume counts Kobe's losses at 378 dead and 134 missing, 5,961 houses swept away or destroyed and a further 26,921 half-destroyed, and sets them beside the damage Osaka and Kyoto had suffered in the Muroto typhoon less than four years earlier. The city itself estimated that around half a million cubic meters of mud and boulders had come down off the mountain. Seven years later the war reached the same streets: Kobe City's official count lists five major American air raids in 1945 — 4 February, 17 March, 11 May, 5 June and 6 August — that between them killed 7,524 people by the city's current figure, injured almost 17,000, and destroyed more than 142,000 houses, forcing over half a million residents from their homes.^{4 14}

Reading the ground today

The waterfront itself was made twice more after the war. In 1987, marking the anniversary of the port's opening, the city filled the sixteen hectares of water between the old Meriken wharf and the 1938 Naka pier to create Meriken Park, setting the Kobe Maritime Museum and, later, the Kobe Port Tower on ground that had been open harbor within living memory. Then, at 5:46 a.m. on 17 January 1995, the Great Hanshin-Awaji earthquake tore through the reclaimed waterfront along with the rest of the city; this dossier's companion Basic brief gives the district's memorials and the city's official casualty figures. The port authority left about sixty meters of the shattered Meriken wharf exactly as the earthquake had cracked and tilted it, opening the site as the Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park in July 1997 and renewing its displays in January 2025 for the disaster's thirtieth anniversary.^{15 16}

Three layers are still there to be read on the ground. The old settlement's grid of streets and its scale of blocks, laid out by Hart in 1868, survive under the banks and offices of the Kyu-Kyoryuchi district even though almost every individual building has been rebuilt. Flower Road, running north from Sannomiya, follows the riverbed Kano Soshichi bought in 1873, and Kano-cho still carries his name. And up on the hill, the houses of Kitano-cho and Yamamoto-dori mark the line foreign residents drew in the 1880s between the settlement where they worked and the slope where they preferred to live — a division the whole city has since grown around.^{8 10 12}

Timeline

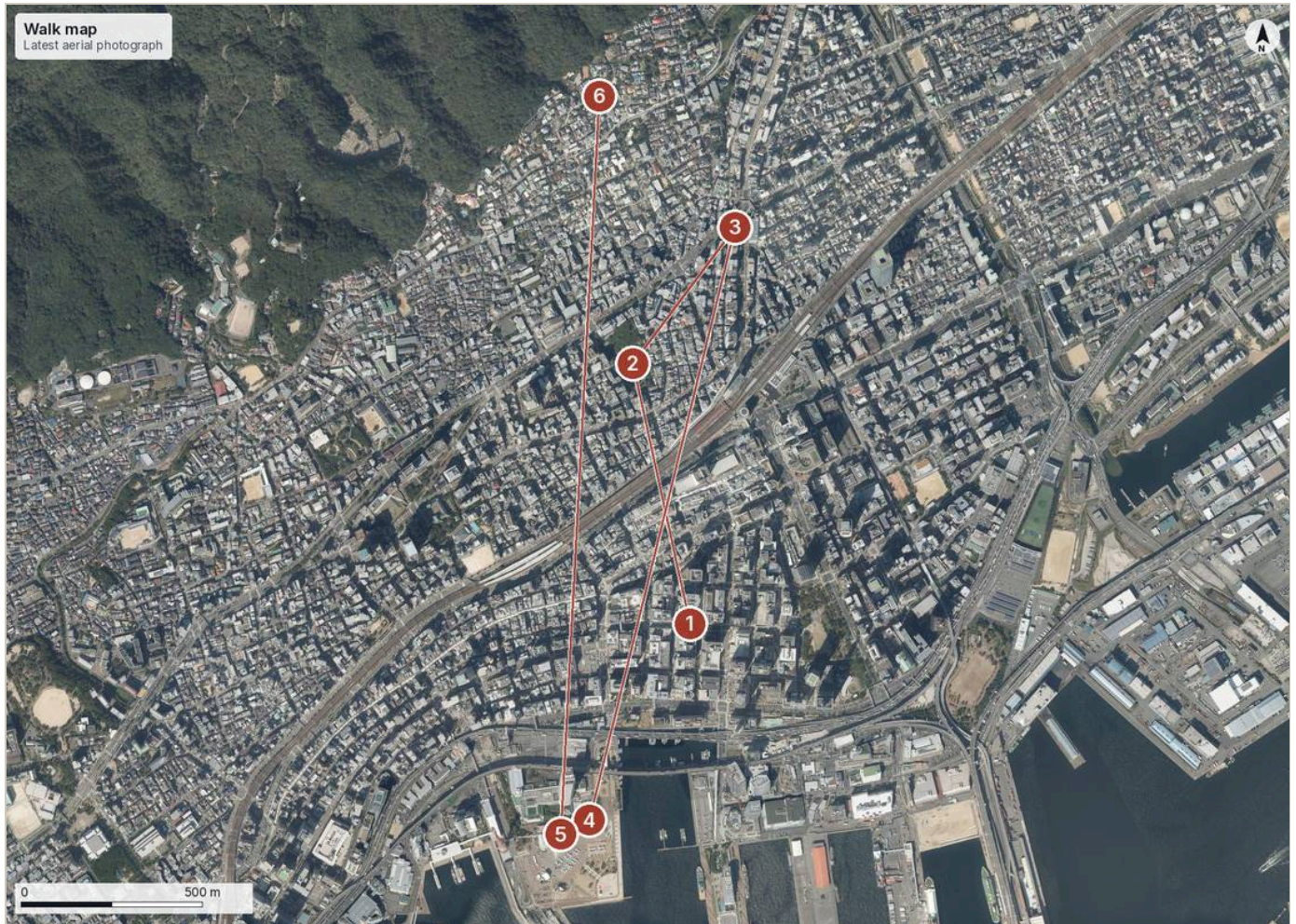
1868 (1 Jan)	Kobe/Hyogo opens to foreign trade; the settlement itself is still unfinished. ¹
1868 (4 Feb)	Bizen domain troops and foreign nationals exchange fire on the Kobe road (the Kobe Incident). ³
1868 (2 Mar)	Taki Zenzaburo commits seppuku at Eifuku-ji, Hyogo, before foreign witnesses, closing the incident. ⁶¹³
1868–1873	J. W. Hart's settlement grid of 126 lots is sold to foreign leaseholders in four auctions. ¹²
1871	The Ikuta River is diverted east over a few months; the old bed is auctioned in 1873 and becomes Kano-cho. ⁶⁸
1875	The Hyogo Shinkawa canal is completed through the old port at Hyogo. ⁵
c. 1887	Foreign residents begin building houses on the Kitano hillside above the settlement. ¹⁰
1899 (17 Jul)	The foreign settlement's special administration ends; Japan resumes full control of the district. ¹²
1938 (5 Jul)	The Great Hanshin flood kills 378 and leaves 134 missing in Kobe by the city's own count. ⁴
1938	The Naka pier, east of Meriken wharf, is completed. ¹⁶
1945	Five major US air raids (Feb, Mar, May, Jun, Aug) kill 7,524 by Kobe City's current figure. ¹⁴
1980 (10 Apr)	Kitano-cho and Yamamoto-dori are designated a national preservation district for traditional buildings. ¹¹
1987	Meriken Park opens on 16 ha reclaimed between the old Meriken wharf and Naka pier. ¹⁶
1995–1997	The Great Hanshin-Awaji earthquake (17 Jan 1995) damages the wharf; the Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park preserving it opens in July 1997. ¹⁵

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1 Kyu-Kyoryuchi (Old Settlement) streets** 旧居留地. Walk the grid of banks and trading-company buildings between Kaigan-dori and the Daimaru department store; the street widths and block sizes are still J. W. Hart's of 1868, even though almost every building standing today was rebuilt after 1945 or 1995.¹² [map](#)
- 2 Ikuta Shrine and Flower Road** 生田神社・フラワーロード. Ikuta Shrine stands near the old river celebrated in classical verse long before 1868; Flower Road, a few minutes' walk to the east, follows the riverbed the city abandoned in 1871 and Kano Soshichi built over in 1873.⁷⁸ [map](#)
- 3 Kano-cho street grid** 加納町. The blocks either side of Flower Road, laid out on the dry riverbed at an unusually generous 18 m road width for 1873, still bear Kano's name.⁶ [map](#)
- 4 Meriken Park and the Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park** メリケンパーク・神戸港震災メモリアルパーク. The park fills the water once open between the 1868 Meriken wharf and the 1938 Naka pier; at its edge, roughly sixty meters of quay wall are left exactly as the 1995 earthquake cracked and tilted them.¹⁵¹⁶ [map](#)
- 5 Kobe Maritime Museum and Kobe Port Tower** 神戸海洋博物館・神戸ポートタワー. Standing on filled ground that was harbor water within living memory, the museum sets Kobe's port history — sail, steam, container — beside the wharves it describes.¹⁶ [map](#)
- 6 Kitano-cho and Yamamoto-dori (Kitano ijinkan-gai)** 北野町・山本通（北野異人館街）. Climb from the settlement to the houses foreign residents built on this slope from about 1887, among them the Weathercock House, within the 9.3 ha preservation district designated in 1980.¹⁰¹¹ [map](#)

Walk map



The walking stops, numbered as in the notes, on the latest GSI aerial photograph (3.5 × 2.5 km, north up). Lines join the stops in order and are not a route; follow streets on the ground. Each stop in the notes links to a map app.

- | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Kyu-Kyoryuchi (Old Settlement) streets map | 4 | Meriken Park and the Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park map |
| 2 | Ikuta Shrine and Flower Road map | 5 | Kobe Maritime Museum and Kobe Port Tower map |
| 3 | Kano-cho street grid map | 6 | Kitano-cho and Yamamoto-dori (Kitano ijinkan-gai) map |

The stops today

Recent photographs of the stops, numbered as in the walking notes. Each was checked against the place the note describes; the line under the name says what it shows.



1. Kyu-Kyoryuchi (Old Settlement) streets

The Old Settlement Hall No.38 at a street crossing in the Old Settlement

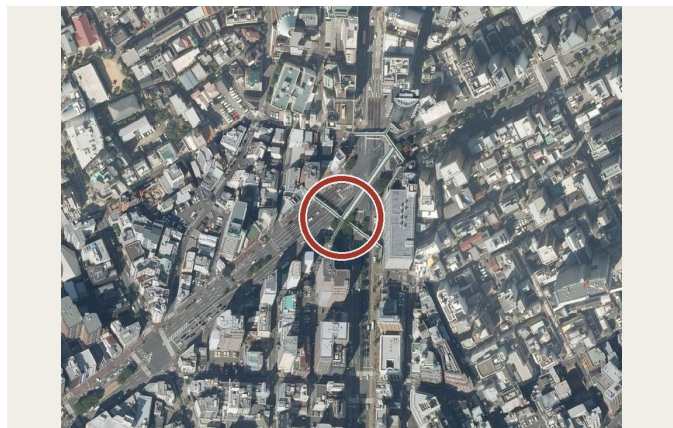
"The old settlement hall of no.38 01s3200" by 663highland, CC BY 2.5, via Wikimedia Commons



2. Ikuta Shrine and Flower Road

The worship hall (haiden) of Ikuta Shrine

"Ikuta-jinja, haiden-1" by Saigen Jiro, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons



3. Kano-cho street grid

No reusable ground-level photograph shows this place, so here is the latest GSI aerial photograph of the spot (ringed), north up, about 480 m across.

Aerial photograph: Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), seamless aerial photos



4. Meriken Park and the Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park

The cracked and tilted quay in the Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park

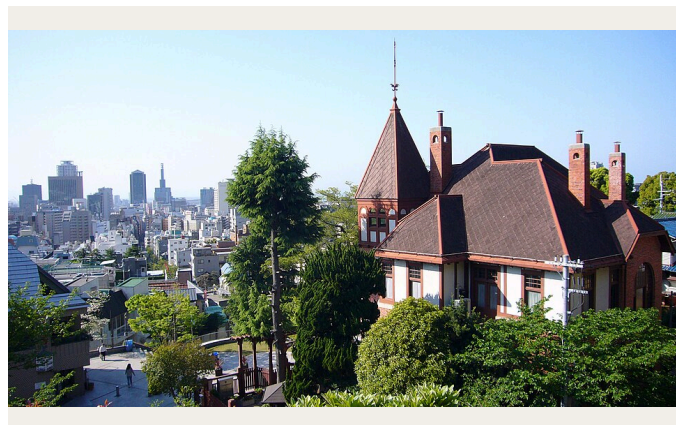
"Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park2" by KENPEI, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons



5. Kobe Maritime Museum and Kobe Port Tower

The Kobe Maritime Museum and its white lattice roof

"Kobe Maritime Museum & Kawasaki GoodTimes World" by Tokumeigakarinoaoshima, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons



6. Kitano-cho and Yamamoto-dori (Kitano ijinkan-gai)

The Weathercock House (old Thomas House) in Kitano-cho, with the city behind

"Kobe kitano thomas house07 2816" by 663highland, CC BY 2.5, via Wikimedia Commons

The same ground, 1945–1950 and 2021



1945–1950 aerial photograph (US military photography) — GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2021 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2021*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



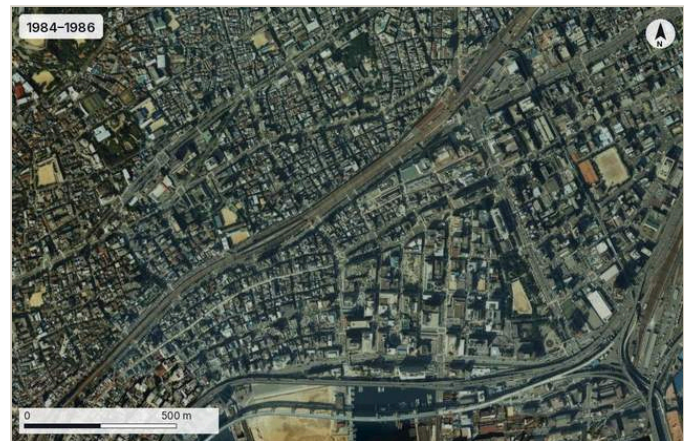
1961-1969 · GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, processed



1974-1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed

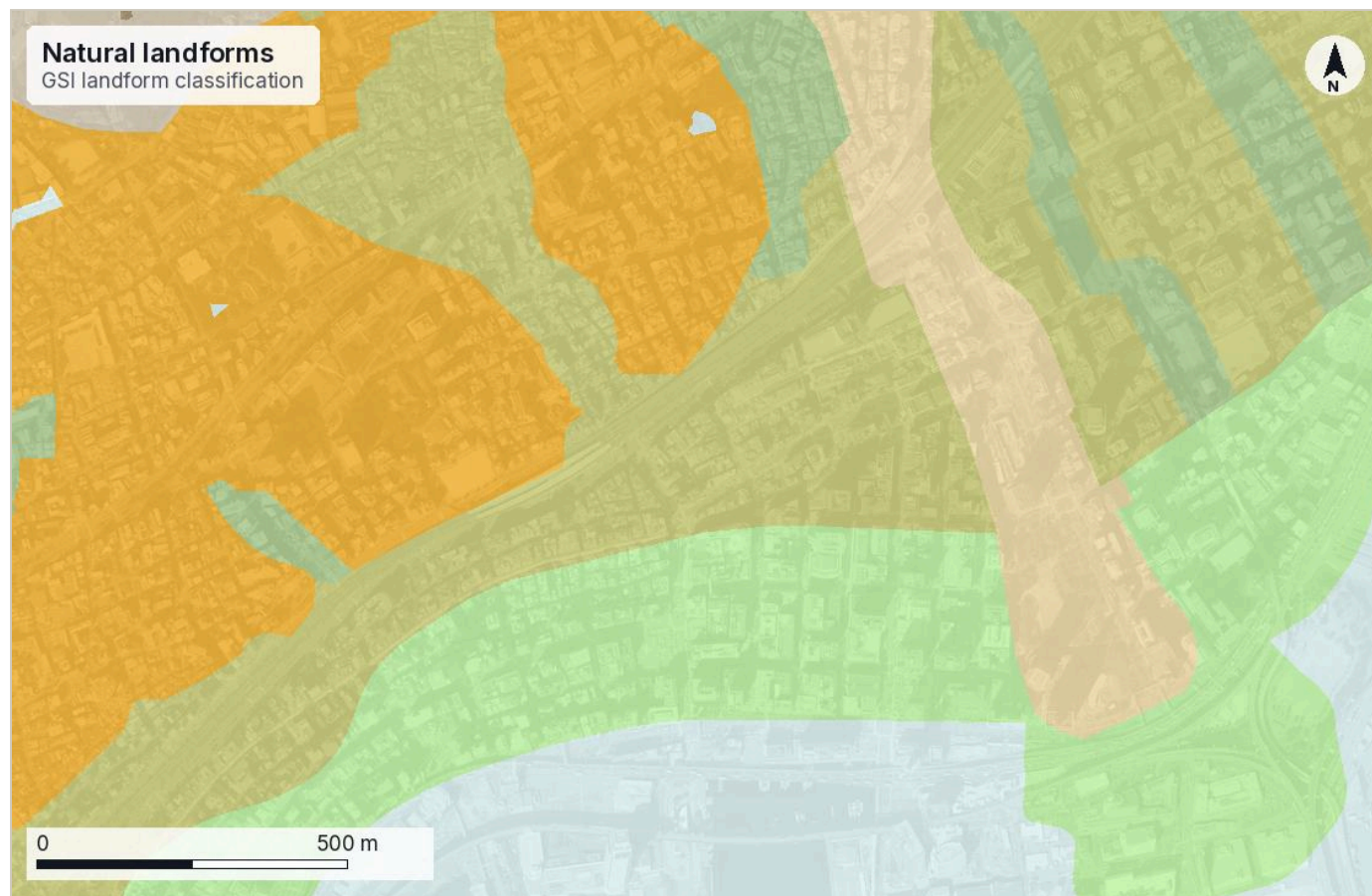


1979-1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed



1984-1986 · GSI Tiles *gazo3*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

 Alluvial fan 26%	 Plateaus and terraces 25%
 Floodplain and coastal plain 21%	 Water 11%
 Hollows and shallow valleys 7.4%	 Raised (perched) river 7.3%
 Mountain and hill slopes 1.9%	

What the main landforms mean

Alluvial fan (26%). Gently sloping ground spreading fan-like from a valley mouth, built from sediment dropped by floods. Floodwater from the mountains, and debris flows near the valley mouth. Relatively firm ground; a slight liquefaction tendency on the lower fan.

Plateaus and terraces (25%). Flat ground standing in steps above its surroundings, left behind as the land around it was eroded. River flooding is rarely a threat unless the terrace is only slightly above the river; watch the slopes at its edges. Firm ground: shaking is relatively weak and liquefaction is unlikely.

Floodplain and coastal plain (21%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

Hollows and shallow valleys (7.4%). Slightly lower ground within terraces, fans or dunes, shaped by small streams or by sediment building up around it. Rainwater gathers here in downpours; the ground can be softer than its surroundings, with a strong liquefaction tendency among sandbars and dunes.

Raised (perched) river (7.3%). Stretches where a river runs higher than the land around it, and the slightly raised ground along them. If a perched river breaks its embankment, floodwater spreads over the surroundings very quickly.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI "Meiji-era lowland" data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s-1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

Man-made ground

-  Filled and reclaimed land 29%
-  Cut ground 13%

Filled and reclaimed land (29%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Cut ground (13%). Ground made by cutting into slopes of mountains or terrace edges. Depending on the cut slope, heavy rain or earthquakes may bring it down; the ground itself is generally firm.

Meiji-era lowland

-  River, pond or sea 7.0%
-  Rice paddy 2.9%

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 6 km across.

Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1 Monument for Remembrance and Reconstruction, with the 1.17 Light of Hope 慰霊と復興のモニュメント・1.17希望の灯り	Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake (17 Jan 1995) · earthquake	2000	0.7 km
2 Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park 神戸港震災メモリアルパーク	Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake (17 Jan 1995) · earthquake	1997	0.7 km
3 Monument to Kano-cho's recovery from the 1938 Hanshin flood 水害復興記念碑	Great Hanshin flood (5 Jul 1938) · flood / landslide or debris flow	c. 1940	0.9 km
4 Kobe Earthquake Reconstruction Memorial Park (Minatonomori Park) 神戸震災復興記念公園(みなとのもり公園)	Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake (17 Jan 1995) · earthquake	2010	1.0 km
5 “Flowing Stones” monument to the 1938 Hanshin flood 流石之碑	Great Hanshin flood (5 Jul 1938) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1939	1.4 km
6 Monument to the recovery from the 1938 Hanshin flood 水害復興記念	Great Hanshin flood (5 Jul 1938) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1938	2.2 km
7 Memorial tower to the victims of the 1938 Hanshin flood 慰霊塔	Great Hanshin flood (5 Jul 1938) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1941	2.3 km
8 Requiem monument to the victims of the 1995 Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake 鎮魂の碑	Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake (17 Jan 1995) · earthquake	2002	2.5 km
9 Memorial to those who died in the 1995 Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake 阪神淡路大震災物故者慰霊碑	Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake (17 Jan 1995) · earthquake	1995	2.7 km
10 Monument of Life (Inochi no Hi) for the 1995 Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake いのちの碑	Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake (17 Jan 1995) · earthquake	2004	2.8 km

What the memorials record

1. **Monument for Remembrance and Reconstruction, with the 1.17 Light of Hope.** The Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake of 17 January 1995 left 6,437 people dead or missing. The monument keeps the disaster in memory, passes on the story of the recovery, honours the victims, encourages citizens and speaks for the value of worldwide solidarity in recovering from major disasters.
2. **Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park.** A 60 m stretch of Meriken Wharf, badly damaged in the Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake of 1995, is preserved as it was left. The park shows how the Port of Kobe was damaged and rebuilt, and hands down

the lessons of the earthquake, the importance of the port and the joint effort that restored it.

3. Monument to Kano-cho's recovery from the 1938 Hanshin flood. Days of summer rain peaked in a downpour on 5 July 1938, setting off debris flows across Mount Rokko and flooding rivers all at once. Torrents from the Nunobiki valley and nearby streams tore into Kano-cho, killing 12 people and damaging over 220 houses. The monument was moved here in March 2007 from 200 m to the north-east.

4. Kobe Earthquake Reconstruction Memorial Park (Minatonomori Park). The park was created as a symbol to nurture the spirit of the aid and volunteers that came from across Japan and the world after the Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake of 1995. Its guiding idea is to watch Kobe move from recovery to growth as its trees grow.

5. "Flowing Stones" monument to the 1938 Hanshin flood. The downpour of 5 July 1938 set off debris flows across Mount Rokko; the Uji and Kusudani rivers in Kusudani-cho overflowed, sweeping away about 150 houses and killing more than 10 people. Made of boulders from the flood, the monument records the damage and notes that, as everyone joined in the recovery, its name may be read "sasuga" ("truly admirable").

6. Monument to the recovery from the 1938 Hanshin flood. The downpour of 5 July 1938 set off debris flows across Mount Rokko, and rivers overflowed all at once. Arata-cho was swept by muddy torrents in an instant, with 125 victims and about 1,800 houses flooded.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

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- 鍋島直身 編 (Nabeshima Naomi, ed.), 神戸名勝案内記 [Guide to the famous places of Kobe], 1897; NDL frames 46, 48.
<https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/765683/1/46> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Classical poems on the Ikuta River and Ikuta-iso beach; the Unai-otome legend; Kano-cho already named on the old riverbed by 1897; facilities built on the new west bank.
- フラワーロードは昔、生田川だった [Flower Road used to be the Ikuta River], 神戸市 (City of Kobe).
<https://www.city.kobe.lg.jp/a43553/kurashi/machizukuri/river/ikuta.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Why and how the Ikuta River was diverted in 1871; Kano Soshichi and Kano-cho; Flower Road; the 1932 culvert blocking in the 1938 flood.
59. どうしてメリケンパークっていうのですか？ [FAQ 59: Why is it called Meriken Park?], 国土交通省近畿地方整備局 神戸港湾事務所 (MLIT Kinki Regional Development Bureau, Kobe Port and Harbor Office). https://www.pa.kkr.mlit.go.jp/kobeport/_um70/59.html, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Origin of the name Meriken Hatoba from "America"; the wharf's site by the former American consulate.
- 北野町・山本通にゆかりの歴史的な建物の魅力 [The charm of the historic buildings of Kitano-cho and Yamamoto-dori], 神戸市 (City of Kobe). <https://www.city.kobe.lg.jp/a21651/kanko/bunka/bunkashisetsu/foreigner/sub1.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Foreign residents building on the hillside from about 1887; more than 200 prewar buildings, about 80 Western-style survivors before the 1995 earthquake.
- 神戸市北野町山本通（重要伝統的建造物群保存地区） [Kobe Kitano-cho Yamamoto-dori (Important Preservation District for Groups of Traditional Buildings)], 文化庁 (Agency for Cultural Affairs). <https://online.bunka.go.jp/heritages/detail/148028>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Designation date (10 April 1980) and area (9.3 ha) of the Kitano-cho/Yamamoto-dori preservation district.
- 旧居留地の歴史 [History of the Old Settlement], 神戸旧居留地 (Kobe Kyu-Kyoryuchi, the Old Settlement district association).
<https://www.kobe-kyoryuchi.com/history/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: J. W. Hart's plan of 126 lots in four auctions (1868–1873); why Kobe rather than Hyogo was chosen; the 1899 return of the settlement to Japanese administration; wartime destruction and postwar revival.
- 神戸事件の責任を取り切腹した備前藩士滝善三郎について知りたい。 [Reference-desk answer on Taki Zenzaburo, the Bizen samurai who committed seppuku over the Kobe Incident], レファレンス協同データベース (Collaborative Reference Database), via NDL.
https://crd.ndl.go.jp/reference/entry/index.php?page=ref_view&id=1000154859, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Taki Zenzaburo's dates and death; his seppuku at Eifuku-ji, Hyogo, on 2 March 1868 before foreign witnesses.
- 神戸空襲 [The Kobe air raids], 神戸市 (City of Kobe). <https://www.city.kobe.lg.jp/a44881/bosai/disaster/war01/war02.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The five major 1945 air raids and the city's current casualty and damage figures.
- 神戸震災メモリアルパーク [Port of Kobe Earthquake Memorial Park], 神戸市港湾局 (City of Kobe, Port and Harbor Bureau).
<https://www.city.kobe.lg.jp/z/kowankyoku/kanko/leisure/harbor/kankou/memorialpark.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Opening in July 1997; about 60 m of the earthquake-damaged Meriken wharf preserved; renewal in January 2025.
- メリケンパーク [Meriken Park], 公益財団法人 日本交通公社 全国観光資源台帳 (Japan Travel and Tourism Association, National Tourism Resources Register). <https://tabi.jtb.or.jp/res/280024->, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Naka pier completed 1938; Meriken Park's 16 ha of reclamation and 1987 opening.
- 旧ハンター住宅 [The former Hunter House], 神戸市立王子動物園 (Kobe Municipal Oji Zoo). <https://www.kobe-ojizoo.jp/area/hunter>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The house stood at Kitano-cho 3-chome until it was moved to the zoo in 1963 (昭和38年); among the largest of Kobe's surviving foreign residences.

Further reading

- 神戸開港三十年史 乾（開港三十年記念会編, 1974） — A thirty-years-on history of the port's opening compiled by anniversary organizers, cited in this dossier's own NDL harvest for river and bridge works around Meriken wharf. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/12061736> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 神戸開港百年史 建設編（神戸開港百年史編集委員会編, 1970） — Centenary construction history of Kobe's port; covers the Ikuta River diversion and harbor works in more engineering detail than this dossier could verify from internet-open frames alone. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/12061747> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 神戸はじめ物語展: 近代都市・神戸のはじまりと開化風俗（神戸市立博物館編, 1987） — Kobe City Museum's own exhibition catalogue on the settlement era; a natural next stop for anyone who wants the museum's fuller visual record. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9576376> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 居留地の窓から: 世界・アジアの中の近代神戸（神戸外国人居留地研究会編, 1999） — A specialist research group's essays on the settlement in its regional and world context; NDL-premises only, but the fullest scholarly treatment found in this harvest. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/14075953> (NDL premises only)
- 使徒たちよ眠れ: 神戸外国人墓地物語（谷口利一 著, 1986） — A history of the Kobe foreign cemetery; useful for anyone tracing individual settlement-era residents by name. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9576338> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- Minute books and land records of the settlement's own foreign municipal council (1868–1899), and the original J. W. Hart plan and land-auction records** — Kobe City Archives (神戸市文書館) and Kobe City Museum (神戸市立博物館), which holds the settlement plan reproduced online. Search the museum's online collection first (heritage id 365270 for the settlement plan), then contact the City Archives' reading room for the council's own minute books and leasehold registers by lot number.
- Full consular correspondence on the Kobe Incident from the British, French, American, Dutch, Prussian and Italian legations** — Japan's Diplomatic Archives (外交史料館) for the Japanese side; the UK National Archives (FO 262 Japan correspondence) and equivalent French, American and Dutch foreign-ministry archives for the foreign side. Diplomatic Archives records can be requested by date and file number through its reading room in Tokyo; foreign archives generally take written requests citing the January–February 1868 date range.
- Mission reports and target photographs for the five 1945 air raids on Kobe** — US National Archives (NARA): XXI Bomber Command mission folders (RG 18) and US Strategic Bombing Survey files (RG 243). Search the NARA online catalog by date and target city; records are open and reproductions can be ordered remotely.
- Administrative and engineering records of the 1938 flood relief and the 1936–1947-era river works on the Ikuta and neighboring rivers** — Hyogo Prefectural Archives and the Kobe City Public Works (土木) records held by the City Archives. Search prefectural and city archive catalogues for 水害 and 河川改修 administrative files from 1938–1947; request in advance for reading-room viewing.
- House-by-house leasehold and rebuilding history of an individual Kitano ijinkan or Kyu-Kyoryuchi lot** — Kobe District Legal Affairs Bureau (closed land registers, 旧土地台帳) and the City's cultural-heritage section, which holds preservation-district survey reports. Request old land registers by lot number at the Legal Affairs Bureau; ask the cultural-heritage section (文化財課) for the building-by-building survey behind the 1980 designation.

Caveats

- Secondary accounts of the Kobe Incident differ on the nationality of the foreign sailors involved (English or French in different popular retellings); the primary correspondence read for this dossier (S3) says only "foreigners" and does not resolve this.
- The 1942 city guidebook (S6) names two successful bidders for the old Ikuta riverbed in 1873, Arimoto Akira and Kano Soshichi, though later tradition and the neighborhood's own name, Kano-cho, remember only Kano.
- Casualty figures for the 1938 flood vary between sources depending on whether the count covers Kobe City alone or the wider Hanshin region, and by date of tally; this dossier uses Kobe City's own contemporary count from its 1939 flood record (S4).
- The Kitano-cho/Yamamoto-dori preservation district's center lies a short distance north of this dossier's formal study-area box; it is treated here in full because it is inseparable from the settlement's history and named in the district's own title.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. Positions of the walking stops: © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL), found with Nominatim. Photographs of the stops: Wikimedia Commons contributors, under the licences named beside each; scaled, not otherwise altered. This experimental edition was checked against its cited sources on 2026-09-28 but has not had independent fact-checking.